Picnic at Treblinka

By Susan Jane Gilman

NARRATOR: **(Pg 203-204)** *(to audience)* To be honest, I don't know a thing about Judaism. Ever since making my grand debut in the sixth grade Christmas pageant, all I'd ever managed to learn about Judaism was that people could kill you for it for no good reason. What was there for Jews to be proud of? Christians had Christmas and Easter bunnies. Granted, heaven and hell seemed to me like transparent attempts at crowd control. But all we Jews seemed to have was the Holocaust. Christians were visited by angels, Jews by the Gestapo. It was no contest.

INTRODUCTION

*Like the majority of young Jewish Americans, Susan Jane Gilman attended a public high school, decorated a Christmas tree each holiday season, and rarely attended synagogue or temple. For her, the Holocaust was just a bit of history. She knew **of** it, yes; but from a very distant and sheltered place.*

When Gilman was sent to Poland as a reporter for the Jewish Weekly to write an article about Jewish history and the Holocaust, she was less than thrilled. In her own words: "I don't mean to be funny. It's just that the world is patently absurd."

In Picnic at Treblinka, Gilman tries valiantly to maintain her off-beat, wry sense of humor until the visceral response becomes too much.

Picnic at Treblinka by Sarah Jane Gilman

4NG Fanatics

NARRATOR: **(Pg 216)** *(to audience)* The week's itinerary read like a vacation package designed by Joseph Goebbels. Tuesday: Treblinka concentration camp. Wednesday: Warsaw ghetto. Thursday: Krakow. Friday: Auschwitz and Birkenau concentration camps.

(Pg 219-220) Treblinka was so pristine, it looked more like an art installation than a concentration camp. The entire site had been demolished by the Nazis in the wake of advancing Allied troops, so the only structures now were memorials. Jagged rocks, each engraved with the name of a town whose population had been annihilated, were scattered around the woodsy site like a haphazard graveyard. Seeing it without knowing the historical context, you'd have absolutely no way of divining what had actually happened there. You might think it was another Stonehenge, a miniature Easter Island.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

A few kids seemed to be under just this impression: they sat down beside one of the memorials and began passing around chicken salad sandwiches.

(sarcastically to traveling companions) Oh look! What a great place for a picnic. Or, better yet, a fashion shoot. Here! *(striking a pose)*

(to audience) I [struck] a pose beside a chunk of granite with the name "Bialystok" etched on it. Bialystok had been the town my grandmother had come from; all her relatives had been killed.

(to traveling companions) Get one of me like this! *(tucking an arm seductively behind head)* For Grandma . . *(bitterly)* Why not? Everyone else here seems determined to pretty things up. *(to audience)* Are you ready for the height of sickness? Check out the souvenir shop. You'll be relieved to know that, at least when I was there, Treblinka sells key rings, change purses, and souvenir bookmarks. *(to saleswoman)* Hey, do you have any bumper stickers that say 'Honk If You Love the Fuhrer'? *(laughing)* Look at these . . . *(to audience)* A rack of postcards with attractive shots of Treblinka on a

4NG Fanatics

sunny day. *(incredulously)* Okay, hands-down, this wins! *(to audience)* We each bought some, along with airmail stamps. *(writing on postcard)* 'Dear Mom. Here I am at Treblinka. As you can see, it is very pretty. The people are friendly. I am having lots of fun"

*****

NARRATOR: **(Pg 221-227)** The highlight took place on Friday -- first to Auschwitz. From there -- two kilometers to Birkenau. Concentration camp prisoners often had to walk from the labor camp to their own extermination. The fields around Auschwitz were flooded with hazy sunshine. Forsythia bloomed on the roadsides. [And] the great irony about Auschwitz -- now you had to pay to get in. Near the entrance was a cafeteria/snack bar, followed by an ice cream stand. As I walked up a stony path, a group of teenagers came barreling up the path.

GIRL: *(excitement of an amusement park)* It's the gate! Quick, you guys, we have to get a picture!

NARRATOR: *(looking and gesturing above to the words)* "Work Makes You Free" -- The famous entrance to Auschwitz, that mocked prisoners as they staggered to their deaths. "Work Makes You Free." In a moment, four

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

of them were posing beneath it, their arms flung around each other chummily, everyone squirming and giggling. One kid made a peace sign with his fingers.

BOY: *(with camera)* Okay, at the count of three, smile and say 'cheese."

GIRL: CHEESE!

NARRATOR: I could see them back home*: (mimicking)* ***Here's me and Jason at Disneyland. Here we are at the junior prom. Oh, and here we are at Auschwitz!*** But then, strangely, I found myself almost gleeful. Hitler, had hoped to turn a handful of synagogues into museums documenting "the extinct Jewish race." Instead, his own machinery had been preserved as a tourist attraction, and now here we were -- kids with cartoon T-shirts, cameras, and picnic lunches, posing beneath the defunct infrastructure of genocide, laughing and squeezing together to fit into the frame. Jews weren't just victims; in the end, we were victors, too!

The Third Reich was gone, but all the people they'd tried to exterminate were still here: the gays, the disabled, the Gypsies, ***and*** the Jews. Just how triumphant was that?

4NG Fanatics

I rounded a corner onto dirt paths to find former barracks where prisoners had slept packed together like cattle. Upstairs, preserved behind a wall of Plexiglas was an enormous pile of hairbrushes and combs -- a hundred thousand of them, piled nearly to the ceiling --and if you looked closely, you could see a few strands of hair in some of them. More disturbingly, the next room was filled with shoes, all sizes and styles-scuffed leather, buckles, lace-ups, high heels -and tiny children's shoes-thousands of pairs, again piled nearly to the ceiling, an avalanche of footwear, all of them bearing the imprints of their former owners.

Six million. Suddenly I could picture the woman in dark green leather pumps with cracked soles, the man with a tortoiseshell comb tucked in his breast pocket. One hair-brush, one belt buckle, and for the first time, the dead became individually palpable. In the next room were eyeglasses, a big, mangled tumbleweed of wire. I wore eyeglasses.

I don't know how I got out of the barracks, or accidentally stumbled into the gas chambers next door --

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

a dank, impassive, clinically tiled room -- or was it concrete? Overhead were big, flat shower heads. Were those fingernail gouges in the walls, or was I imagining things?

The first time I'd heard about the gas chambers was when my friend Ruthie had told me there was a man named Hitler who'd made all the Jews take off their clothes and go into a big group shower where poison gas came out of the pipes instead of water. *(as a child to Ruthie)* So wait, before the showers, they didn't even let you wear towels? *(to audience)* Now, here I was, in a gas chamber myself. The room seemed to vibrate with malignancy and pain. I was out of jokes; I was utterly alone.

Adjacent to the showers was a crematorium. The ovens were reddish brick, long and deep, with human-sized spatulas protruding from them. -- there was no mistaking their purpose.

Until that moment, I'd somehow assumed that the Holocaust had been meant for ***other*** people -- for ***real*** Jews, Jews who actually cared about their religion. Jews

4NG Fanatics

who had been weak or naive. Jews who hadn't been nearly as savvy, charming, or modern as ***my*** family was. Surely, ***we*** would have been spared. Surely, ***we*** would have figured out some way to wriggle out of it, to be granted an exemption from a fate reserved for six million others. Surely, the Nazis would at some point have realized that they were making a terrible mistake. Look: We had a Christmas tree! I'd sung in a choir!

At some point, I suppose, all of us in our lives confront some unavoidable, outsized horror. Maybe it's a tumor, or a little brother playing with a gun, or a psychopath in a day care center; but inevitably, a moment comes for all of us when we realize that we cannot beat the devil on this one: we have been targeted for injustice or tragedy. And nothing in school, nothing in daily life really prepares us for ***this***.

At twenty-two years old, I'd remained strangely naive. Now, staring into an oven designed specifically for me -- me in my shoes and eyeglasses -- I was suddenly aware of just how spoiled and ill-equipped I was to cope with the viciousness of the world. What the hell did I know? I

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

4NG fanatics

was just some ambitious little *jerk* from New York.

I wanted to go home and curl into a feral position in my bedroom. I'd happily forfeit substance and forgo all wisdom if it meant I'd never have to recognize ***this***. I had the urge to rip open my own skin, crawl out of it, and leave it behind as I fled. As if cued, the sky became overcast, and a soft rain began falling as we marched past the ominous watchtowers and under the brick archway of Birkenau, where railway tracks ran, then came, chillingly, to a halt.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Susan Jane Gilman
Book: Hypocrite in a Pouffy White Dress, Pgs 203-227
ISBN: 978-0446679497
Publisher: Grand Central Publishing
Date (Month/Year): Jan 2005

AWARD HISTORY

2009 National Qualifier
IL State Qualifier

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY